AUTISM-READY LIBRARIES

Autism Information & Resources

This information and resource list provides basic information about autism and neurodiversity, and provides links to resources that can be used by both library professionals and families including:

- Information about autism and neurodiversity
- Resources and their uses

INSTITUTE of Museum and Library SERVICES

Information School UNIVERSITY of WASHINGTON

AUTISM-READY LIBRARIES

What is Autism?

"Autism is a developmental disability that affects how we experience the world around us. Autistic people are an important part of the world. Autism is a normal part of life, and makes us who we are."

–Autistic Self Advocacy Network (ASAN) "About Autism"

- Autism is a natural human variance
- Autism has always existed
- Autistic people are born autistic and will be autistic their whole lives
- Autism occurs among all racial, ethnic, and socioeconomic groups

CDC, 2020

Every autistic person is different, but there are some common experiences:

Cognitive differences – Many autistic individuals process information differently, and can provide a new perspective of the world. Autistic people may need more time to process information, but often with excellent attention to detail.

Sensory processing differences – Autistic individuals may be sensitive to lights and sounds, and some may seek sensory input. Many autistics have increased sound perception, and can detect individual sounds in noisy rooms.

Communication differences – Autistic individuals are often honest and literal when communicating. Some may be nonspeaking or only speak when comfortable, preferring to communicate with other methods.

Social differences – Autistic people enjoy sharing their knowledge and interests. Eye contact may be uncomfortable for some autistic individuals.

Support differences – Some autistic individuals need additional support accessing library services. Many autistics find comfort in clearly defined rules and guidance.

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What is Neurodiversity?

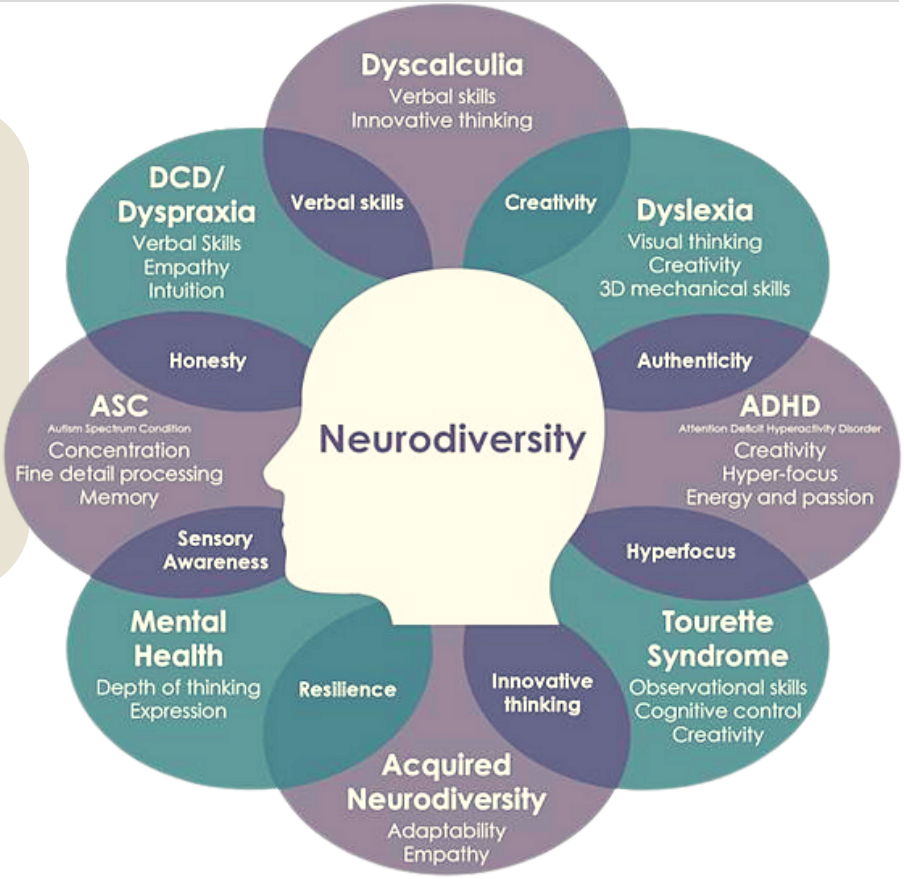
The term neurodiversity describes the natural variation of human brains in the ways people think, process information, and behave. Neurodiversity includes many different ways of thinking and being, such as autism or ADHD.

Neurodiversity does not treat autism or other forms of neurodivergence as a deficit but as a natural form of human variation. Neurodiversity recognizes that differences also include strengths.

Many autistic people refer to themselves as neurodivergent.

Improvements made to public library spaces, customer services, and user policies to better include autistic individuals can also be used to support other neurodiverse users.

This graphic demonstrates some of the overlapping strengths of neurodiversity, as outlined by Dr. Nancy Doyle. By recognizing these strengths, we can move beyond stereotypes to improve our understanding of the experiences of neurodivergent people.



Resources for Information & Services

Autistic Self Advocacy Network (ASAN) - https://autisticadvocacy.org/

ASAN is an organization run by and for autistic people, and is committed to making our society more inclusive for autistic people. ASAN provides a large resource library including toolkits for new parents, and accessibility resources for professionals.

Autistic Women and Nonbinary Network (AWN) - https://awnnetwork.org/

AWN is committed to disability justice, racial equity, neurodiversity, and trans liberation with a focus on transformative and restorative justice in disability spaces. AWN provides excellent resources such as welcome packets for parents of newly diagnosed children, and webinars for professionals.

The Arc - https://thearc.org/

The Arc's mission is to promote and protect the human rights of intellectually and developmentally disabled individuals and actively support their full inclusion and participation in the community throughout their lifetimes. The Arc provides resources and services for local parents and professionals, including training. Check out your local chapter to find more information.

The Autism Society - https://autismsociety.org/

The Autism Society's mission is to empower everyone in the autism community with the resources needed to live fully. They connect people to resources through education, advocacy, support, information and referral, and community programming. The Autism Society provides screening and diagnosis resources, as well as many other resources for autistic individuals and their families including housing, employment, and public policy resources.

Autistikids - http://www.autistikids.com/

Autistikids is a website with the mission to quickly and easily connect people who are interested in learning about autism from a wide range of people who are autistic. Autistikids is a resource for families, autistic children, and allies to learn more about autism, parenting autistic children, and supporting them through adulthood.